

[ENTER COMPANY NAME]

QUALITY MANAGEMENT SYSTEM

STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE

Complaint Handling and Post-Market Intake

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Applicable Regulatory Standards	ISO 13485:2016 Clause 8.2.2 & 8.5.1 FDA 21 CFR Part 820.198 EU MDR 2017/745 Article 83-86

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1.0 Purpose

This Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) governs the systematic intake, documentation, triage, investigation, and operational tracking of written, electronic, or oral communications alleging deficiencies related to the identity, quality, durability, reliability, safety, effectiveness, or performance of distributed medical devices. The primary focus of this program is to ensure quick regulatory assessment for adverse events and establish a reliable data feed for post-market surveillance metrics.

2.0 Scope

This procedure is mandatory for all inbound post-commercialization feedback received from healthcare practitioners, institutional accounts, end-users, field clinical technicians, third-party sales channel agents, or regulatory inspectorates. This SOP mandates structural actions across the entire lifecycle of an incoming report, beginning from initial notification to final investigation closure.

3.0 Responsibility and Authority

3.1 Customer Services / Frontline Intake Personnel

Responsible for recording all inbound commercial communications verbatim, documenting primary demographic contact fields, identifying device control lots/serial sequences, and immediately escalating potential functional issues to Quality Assurance within 24 hours of notification receipt.

3.2 Complaint Unit Investigator (QA Department)

Responsible for performing procedural file evaluations, requesting physical device retention returns, formulating formal internal validation testing protocols, evaluating manufacturing records, and ensuring completion of comprehensive failure analysis files.

3.3 Regulatory Affairs Officer

Holds absolute accountability to execute mandatory screenings for reporting obligations to international administrative panels (such as FDA MedWatch MDRs, European EUDAMED MIR reports, and Health Canada adverse notifications) within legally dictated timelines.

4.0 Procedure

4.1 Intake and Verification Baseline

All operational personnel receiving communication from field users must collect core info, even if the user cannot verify all elements. The baseline data package must contain:

- Unique Reporter identity metrics, facility address, and email coordinates.
- Explicit device name, corporate item reference catalog identifier, and lot/serial identification numbers.

- A thorough technical description of the perceived failure anomaly, clinical environment details, and clinical patient outcomes (if any).

4.2 Triage Matrix and Adverse Event Screening

Every recorded report file must undergo systemic classification triage within 48 hours of initial intake. The screening matrix assesses the event profile against regulatory definitions:

Triage Category	Underlying Technical Attributes	Operational Escalation Timeline
Category A (Critical Event)	The failure caused or contributed to a patient death, life-threatening injury, permanent impairment, or structural clinical intervention.	Immediate escalation to VP Regulatory Affairs. Review required within 24 hours.
Category B (Malfunction Risk)	The device malfunctioned or failed to meet specifications, and would likely cause death or serious injury if the malfunction were to recur in the field.	Escalation to QA Manager within 3 business days. Regulatory assessment mandated.
Category C (Non-Adverse Feedback)	Clerical errors on shipping manifests, aesthetic external packaging flaws, or minor logistical issues.	Standard logging. Normal routing within 10 business days.

4.3 Physical Sample Retrieval and Laboratory Evaluation

The assigned Investigator must issue a written request to the clinical site to return the affected hardware sample. If the device sample is successfully retrieved, it must undergo decontamination according to hazard handling specifications. Evaluation methods may involve bench performance testing, non-destructive optical scans, X-ray checks, or destructive teardowns to isolate technical root causes.

REGULATORY RETENTION COMPLIANCE: If an institutional site refuses to return a device involved in a critical event, the file investigator must document all communication logs, formal emails, and return-kit tracking manifests to show evidence of due diligence.

4.4 Device History Review (DHR) Matrix

A comprehensive review of the Device History Record for the specific batch or lot number must be executed. The investigator must examine raw material certificates, cleanroom environment charts, in-process bioburden testing data, and final release sterilization reports to determine if manufacturing errors occurred during fabrication.

4.5 Reporting Assessments and CAPA Alignment

If the regulatory assessment indicates that an incident meets adverse event criteria, the Regulatory Affairs Officer must transmit formal notifications to regulatory bodies. This step must comply with strict national reporting timelines

(e.g., 5-day or 30-day FDA deadlines, 15-day EU MDR metrics). On a quarterly basis, complaint trend thresholds are reviewed; if a specific failure mechanism crosses historical limits, a formal Corrective and Preventive Action (CAPA) file must be opened.

5.0 Records Lifecycle and Governance

All records associated with incoming complaints, including original communications, laboratory notes, and final regulatory responses, must be maintained securely. Records are archived for a minimum duration of five (5) years from file closure, or for the active lifetime of the device model as specified by global regulatory standards.

6.0 Associated Reference Materials

- **SOP-RA-004:** Post-Market Surveillance Program
- **SOP-RA-005:** Vigilance and Adverse Event Reporting Architecture
- **SOP-QA-006:** Corrective and Preventive Action (CAPA) System
- **Form-QA-003A:** Post-Market Complaint Intake File Form

7.0 Revision History Log

Revision Level	Effective Date	Author / Originator	Detailed Description of Modifications
00	[Date]	[Name], Post-Market QA	Initial baseline release of formalized Complaint Handling and Post-Market Intake Standard Operating Procedure.